and told me not to worry, but I was stunned by the ferocity of the criticism from someone I respected so much. Ray had a point, of course, and, looking back, I understand that he was so disappointed and so angry precisely because he recognised I could achieve something in the game and he didn't want me to waste that potential.

Ray remains one of the outstanding coaches of my career and a man who has my complete respect; as the years went by, I did play for him again and we were destined to enjoy many great days together, with him as the coach and me as a player, with the Proteas and then with Royal Challengers Bangalore in the Indian Premier League.

Back at SuperSport Park, Zander de Bruyn and Hashim Amla scored excellent centuries and the A team 'Test' meandered to a draw. A second match followed at Willowmoore Park in Benoni and, having managed to keep my place in the side, we dismissed New Zealand A for 127 and were left only 39 runs to win. Under no pressure, opening the batting again, it seemed reasonable to attack the bowling, so I played some shots and scored a brisk 32 runs from 20 balls, including five boundaries.

Then the experienced Boeta Dippenaar was recalled to take his place in the third 'Test' in Potchefstroom, replacing me and opening the batting with Puttick … and Boeta scored a century.

What now?

Returning to the relative safety of the Titans squad, my fortunes did not improve as we opened our SuperSport Series campaign by losing at home to the Eagles. I kept wicket again, which was fine because it kept me involved in the game, but scored four when batting at No. 6 in the first innings, and then managed only 12 runs, albeit including a four and a six, when batting even further down at No. 8 in our second innings.

I was down, but I was up again the following week when we played Western Province in Benoni, scoring 151 in a really enjoyable second-wicket partnership of 317 with Martin van Jaarsveld. Graeme Smith, the South African captain, was playing for Western Province, and I